

Google Refines Search; Halts Street View in Bangalore

Google has come up with yet another advanced feature called Instant Pages that predicts the link users wants to use and begins fetching its data – even before the user has clicked on the link. The new feature, expected to save 2-5 seconds on search query time, is based on Google Instant, which furnishes search results even before the user has finished typing the query or pressed the enter key. This feature is likely to be included in the newest test version of Google Chrome browser.

Apart from Instant Pages, Google has also unveiled two more major updates to its search engine – Google Voice Search and Google Search By Image.



Voice Search allows users to search by just speaking the search keywords. The feature will be available to Chrome users initially. Currently, only English vocals are accepted. Google expects to support other languages in the near future.

Google "Search By Image" enables users to search for images by just dragging a sample image to the search box. Understanding your request,

the search engine goes on a quest for similar images. Google, however, has made it clear that the new image search feature won't support face recognition technology.

A little earlier in the month, Google also unveiled flight schedule search. Ever since news of Google's acquisition of ITA, last year, we were wondering when we'd see something in the flight search domain.

Google insists that it didn't use ITA technology for the new feature, so we should wait and see what that will bring. Perhaps, even richer flight options and searches, as well as price searches.

Now, all you need is to decide on a destination, and when you enter a simple query such as 'flights from [source] to [destination],' you'll get non-stop flight schedules, or a summary of daily flight details. A full timetable is available as well, in a link entitled "Schedule of non-stop flights." Multi-city flights aren't supported yet. The feature will also allow users to see all the destinations possible from a particular airport, by searching for 'flights from [source].' For now, though the service has been launched globally, it's available in ten languages – English, French, Italian, German, Spanish, Dutch, Brazilian Portuguese, Polish, Russian, Turkish and Catalan.

In other news, Google was compelled to halt its ambitious "Street View" campaign in Bangalore after the local police raised objections on the move. Almost three weeks ago, Google's Street View cars started driving around Bangalore to take high definition images to provide users a 360-degree view of streets. Reports said that the local police raised objections to this data collection. Confirming the news, Google said that it was scrutinising the letter issued by the Bangalore police and has grounded the fleet until the matter is sorted out. ■

Fake Microsoft Updates for Firefox Users

Homely masks are becoming more common than invisibility cloaks in the world of cyber-crime, and from fake anti-virus software to malware warnings, we've now reached a stage when a malicious script is masquerading as a Microsoft Update. These are just a part of what experts like to call "social engineering tricks," scareware preying by deception.

Firefox users on Windows can be directed via a pop-up warning to a page that is the spitting image of the

Microsoft Update page. What's different, however, is that the particular Microsoft Update



displayed requires the use of Internet Explorer. Unwary

users can proceed to download some nasty stuff, if they decide to install the so called urgent update.

For now, the only safety is being a wary customer in the face of pop-up warnings and notifications. Do also check for security certificates displayed by your browser on secure, signed pages. With all this going around, we can't help but feel the future of security is a bit bleak, and perhaps the combination of common sense and a good anti-virus package won't be enough. ■